ond, the party's organisational structure was hollow at the grassroots. The BJP had become excessively dependent on turncoats, part-time politicians and celebrities to contest. These candidates brought visibility and, occasionally, votes, but they lacked booth networks, local credibility and any long-term stake in organisation-building. Third, factionalism had quietly eroded any semblance of structural coherence. Local units were divided, loyalties were personal rather than institutional and coordination between the state leadership and district units was frequently dysfunctional.

Modi then asked Union home minister Amit Shah to personally anchor the Bengal campaign. Shah understood that Bengal could not be fought like a conventional election; it needed a multi-layered command operation, centralised in vision but decentralised in execution. He brought in one of his most trusted aides, BJP general secretary Sunil Bansal, who had previously overseen the party's organisation-building in Uttar Pradesh and delivered Odisha in 2024. Bansal was asked to focus exclusively on Bengal and rebuild the organisation from the ground up. His first step was diagnostic: travelling extensively across districts, holding closed-door meetings and mapping organisational gaps at the booth and mandal levels.

Home minister Amit Shah knew Bengal would not be a conventional election. It would need a multi-pronged approach: centralised in vision but decentralised in execution

Bansal understood from the outset that Bengal's problem was not one of messaging or resources. It was structural, and it could only be addressed through the Sangh's deep volunteer network. From the RSS to the Vishwa Hindu Parishad, Bajrang Dal to the Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram, Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh to student organisations operating across university campuses in the state, every affiliate was brought into a single coordinated framework. The RSS deputed joint general secretary Alok Kumar in August 2024 to work closely with Bansal. The Sangh was not asked merely to campaign, affiliates were involved in designing the campaign, identifying booth-level weaknesses, selecting candidates and, crucially, executing the campaign strategy on the ground in the months leading up to polling day.

Under Modi-Shah's direction, Bansal then launched the Sadasyata Abhiyan in October 2024, with the ambitious target of enrolling 10 million members. Transforming the exercise into a tool for organisational layering, Bansal introduced the concept of "active members"—those responsible for enrolling at least 100 primary members—and created a middle tier of accountable grassroots leadership. This ensured the expansion was not merely numerical but structurally embedded. By poll day, the party claimed to have around 60,000 active members who had collectively enrolled nearly 8 million primary members.

Geographically, the campaign was divided into five zones, each monitored by a Union minister paired with a veteran organisational hand. Across the state, the BJP deployed nearly 950,000 booth-level *karyakartas*, averaging roughly a dozen workers per booth. Alongside them were more than 300,000 *panna pramukhs*, each assigned a list of 60-70 voters, creating a direct line of contact that extended deep into households. In the most competitive booths, this translated into roughly one worker per 50-60 voters. Equally significant was Bansal's emphasis on monitoring and discipline. Daily reporting via late-night video conferences introduced a corporate-style review mechanism. His message was unequivocal: advancement would depend on measurable performance, not proximity to leadership.

Simultaneously, the BJP's Bengal unit built a granular electoral machine around the state's 78,903 polling booths, treating

ALL THE KEY PLAYERS

West Bengal was not just any election. By the end, it became a meticulous operation drawing authority from the central government and heft from constituency-level mobilisation of BJP workers

The Chief Campaigner
NARENDRA MODI

The prime minister served as the BJP's force multiplier throughout the campaign, leaving nothing to chance in the battleground state. His appeal among women, tribal communities and Scheduled Castes was solidified by his pitch of direct benefit transfers—a direct counter to Mamata Banerjee's 15-year-long model of governance that relied heavily on welfarism. What tipped the balance, ultimately, were claims of credibility



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR